load on them [Afghan Taliban] so as to break the relationship ... let it evolve and see where it goes', he says.[109]

The Afghan Taliban's interest in engaging with India raises another question —is the Haqqani network necessarily opposed to India (or, as Menon says, happy to be manipulated by Pakistan)? In a testimony to the US Senate Committee on Armed Services, in September 2011, Admiral Mike Mullen, former chairman of the US Joint Chiefs of Staff, described the Haqqani network as a 'veritable arm' of the ISI.[110] Parallel to his testimony were assurances by Pakistan that it could credibly 'persuade' the Haqqani leadership to participate in talks with the Karzai government.[111] Such statements reflected the confidence that Rawalpindi had its influence over the Haqqanis, a fact that worried India considerably. However, independent scholarship shows that despite being closely linked with Pakistan's security agencies, the Haqqanis may not necessarily be totally 'dependent' on Pakistan's support.[112] Geographically focused in the border areas of Afghanistan and Pakistan, the network enjoys considerable financial, political, and military independence. Linked to the wider jihadist network the Haqqanis actively interact with Al Qaeda, the Afghan Taliban, the TTP, the LeT, and other smaller militant groups that benefit from the illicit drug economy in the region. Such linkages allow the Haqqani Network (HN) to have a transactional relationship with the ISI where both parties benefit from the other as allies instead of being subservient to Pakistan's diktats.

Though the HN helped execute the 2008 Indian embassy bombing (among other attacks on NATO installations), the precise motivations for the same are not clear. If the motivations were monetary and not ideological (a scenario that is highly probable), then the HN can be manipulated by powers other than Pakistan as well. For some Pakistan-watchers, the possibility of HN using the Pakistan's security establishment for their own strategic ends is equally high and makes the group open to engagement with extra-regional powers in south and central Asia.[113] The scenario of Indian intelligence services opening a channel with Serajuddin Haqqani, who is now second-in-command in the Taliban hierarchy, after Haibatullah Akhundzada (who became Taliban's chief after Mullah Akhtar Mansour's assassination in a US drone strike in May 2016), or counter-bribing the HN, cannot be discounted (though there is little political